

Issue 51 - 10/10 onboarding PDF

This revision addresses the PR comment by turning the PDF from a simple before/after note into a competitive onboarding audit, quickstart blueprint, and reviewer handoff for Codexa new-user education.

Reviewer ask	How this PDF addresses it
More comprehensive	Adds competitive scan, gap analysis, recommended flow, diagrams, screenshots, validation, and source appendix.
Competitive analysis	Compares onboarding patterns from Claude Code, Cursor, Aider, Continue, GitHub Copilot, OpenAI Codex CLI, and MCP docs.
What are we missing?	Separates what PR #53 already fixes from remaining gaps such as success criteria, troubleshooting branches, and example-task specificity.
Good quickstart flow	Defines a Codexa-specific first-run ladder from prerequisite check to evidence-backed PR.
Diagrams	Includes a 10/10 onboarding flow diagram and a readiness troubleshooting decision tree.

Executive read

- PR #53 is directionally right: the README now gives first-time users an obvious tutorial handoff instead of stopping at commands.
- The best competing tutorials do not merely install a tool. They move users through a first useful task, a review/acceptance moment, troubleshooting, and next steps.
- Codexa onboarding should be explicit about its unusual value: source-local context, saved change plans, post-edit drift review, and verification crediting.
- The next-best tutorial improvement after this PR is a copy-paste sample repository walkthrough with expected command output and a small intentionally changed file.

Research date: 2026-06-16. Sources are listed on the final page.

What strong AI coding tool tutorials do

The useful pattern across mature onboarding docs is a progression from prerequisites to one concrete useful change, then review, verification, and next-step branching.

Source	Observed onboarding pattern	Codexa implication
Claude Code	Install, log in, start in a project, ask the first question, make a first code change, use git, fix a bug, then common workflows.	Codexa should show a first question and first edit loop, not only init commands.
Cursor	Frames quickstart as install to first useful change: sign in, ask about the codebase, make a small edit, and review the result.	Codexa should prove the first useful win: read-first files, saved plan, review result, and tests.
Aider	Starts with install, cd into the codebase, model/API setup, and direct start-working commands.	Codexa should keep copy-paste terminal commands but immediately explain target repo vs Codexa checkout.
Continue Agent Mode	Explains the mode value first: an agent can implement changes, fix bugs, and run commands with tools.	Codexa should explain that it is not the editor/agent; it governs context and verification around the agent.
GitHub Copilot	Splits by environment, lists prerequisites, then walks a concrete chat/agent task and review/keep step.	Codexa should split Codex CLI vs Claude Code wiring and show what success looks like in each host.
OpenAI Codex CLI	Positions local terminal agent capabilities and links to reference/config maturity pages.	Codexa should make host relationship clear: Codexa serves Codex/Claude via MCP and does not mutate source through MCP.
MCP docs	Build tutorials show system requirements, working example, host/server relationship, and next steps.	Codexa should diagram host -> MCP server -> repo index -> agent decision loop.

A good quickstart flow for Codexa

A Codexa quickstart should convert a cold user into someone who has seen one evidence-backed edit loop complete in their own repository.

10/10 first-run ladder



Non-negotiable onboarding checkpoints

- State the product boundary early: Codexa is a local context and verification guide, not an autonomous coding agent.
- Use one tiny realistic task that demonstrates the unique loop: task brief, saved change plan, edit, post-edit review, and test plan.
- Show expected output classes, not exact machine-specific output: fresh/stale/missing-index, parser errors, dirty file count, and verdicts.
- Include recovery branches for the first three failures: command not found, missing index, and MCP tools not appearing in the host.
- End with a checklist a user can verify: files read, planned scope, dirty tree scope, commands run, and remaining risk.

What the current PR fixes and what remains

PR #53 improves discoverability and gives a coherent first setup path. The remaining work is mostly about making the tutorial runnable as a guided exercise rather than only explanatory.

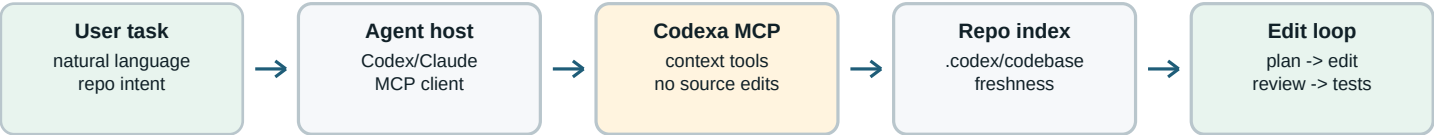
Area	Before PR #53	Current PR #53	10/10 next step
README handoff	Quick Start ended at setup commands.	README links to the new tutorial immediately after init/session-start commands.	Keep this placement; it is the right first-viewport handoff for new users.
First-run story	No standalone new-user journey.	Tutorial walks install, repo wiring, readiness, edit loop, success, and troubleshooting.	Add a complete sample task with expected output snippets and a tiny fixture repository.
Host clarity	Codex vs Claude wiring was present but dense.	Tutorial separates Codex CLI and Claude Code init paths.	Add a matrix for Codex CLI, Claude Code, and ad hoc npx serve.
Evidence loop	Everyday workflow existed in README but was abstract.	Tutorial names brief, change-plan, post-edit-review, and test-plan in sequence.	Show one concrete before/after dirty tree and the exact interpretation of continue/inspect/replan.
Troubleshooting	Scattered across command docs.	Tutorial covers PATH, missing-index, missing tools, wrong repo, heuristic output.	Add decision-tree anchors and doctor output examples.
Diagrams	No visual onboarding map.	This PDF adds diagrams for reviewer handoff.	Consider adding a lightweight Mermaid or ASCII diagram to the tutorial if repo docs allow it.

DIAGRAM

Codexa onboarding architecture

The first-run tutorial should make this relationship obvious: the agent host asks Codexa for context, Codexa reads local repo/index state, and the user still owns edits and verification.

Host, server, repo, and proof flow

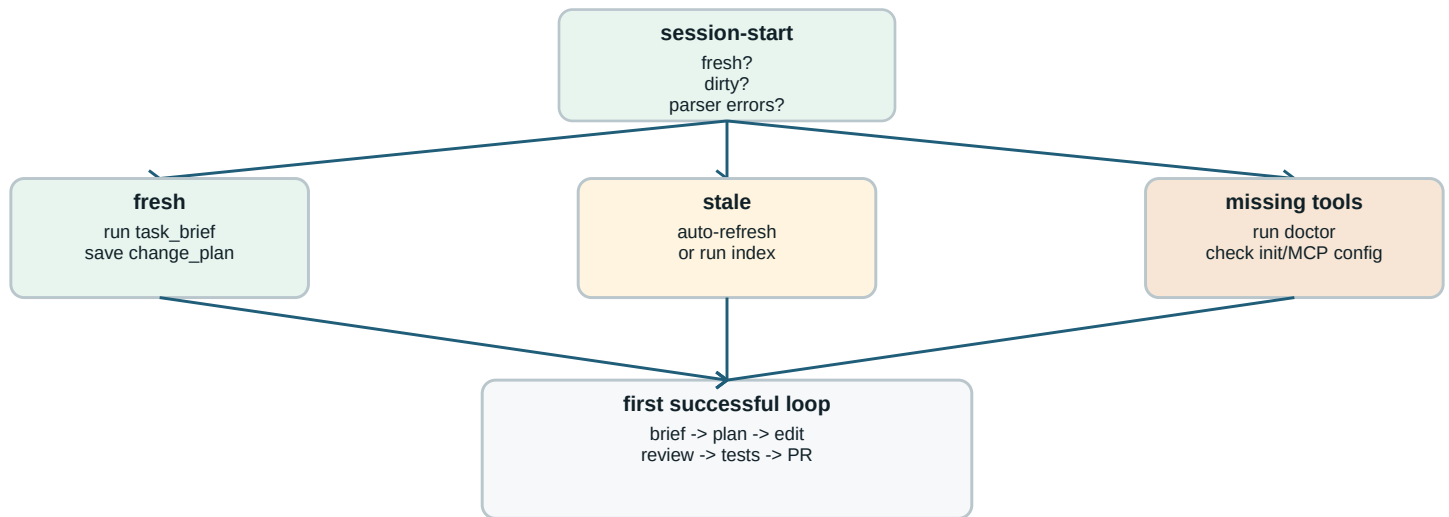


Element	New-user wording that should be explicit
Agent host	The thing you interact with: Codex CLI, Claude Code, or another MCP client.
Codexa MCP server	The local evidence server that supplies context packets and review guidance. It does not edit source files.
Generated index	The local map under .codex/codebase/ and cache state under .codex/cache/.
Proof loop	The sequence that makes Codexa valuable: task brief, saved plan, post-edit review, and verification credit.

DIAGRAM

Readiness and troubleshooting decision tree

A 10/10 quickstart needs a visible recovery path. New users should not be stranded when their first session reports stale or missing artifacts.



Tutorial gaps this diagram exposes

- Add a compact table that maps session-start states to next action: fresh, fresh-with-dirty-overlay, stale, missing-index, parser errors, MCP unavailable.
- Add one doctor example that shows what to check when tools do not appear in the host.
- Explain when auto-refresh is enough and when the user should explicitly run codexa index.

Before Screenshot

README Quick Start on origin/main. Users saw install and init commands, but no tutorial handoff.

PR #53 BASELINE

Before: Quick Start stopped at commands

No start-to-finish tutorial handoff was present in the Quick Start path.

Quick Start

Codexa requires Node.js 22 or newer.

Install from npm:

```
npm install -g @mirnoorata/codexa
```

Or work from a checkout:

```
git clone https://github.com/mirnoorata/codexa.git
cd codexa
npm install
npm run build
npm link
```

Wire Codexa into another repository:

```
codexa init /path/to/project          # Codex CLI: .codex/config.toml + hooks
codexa init /path/to/project --claude # also writes a repo-root .mcp.json for Claude Code
codexa session-start /path/to/project
```

After `codexa init`, the target repository gets a repo-local `.codex/config.toml` entry that lets Codex discover the Codexa MCP server automatically, and with `--claude` a repo-root `.mcp.json` so Claude Code discovers the same server (only the codexa entry is managed; other servers in an existing `.mcp.json` are preserved, and malformed JSON aborts the write). When init runs from an evictable npx cache, generated configs pin `npx -y @mirnoorata/codexa@<version>` instead of the cache path so they keep working after a cache prune.

After Screenshot

README Quick Start on PR #53. The new tutorial link is visible immediately after the setup commands.

PR #53 CHANGE

After: Quick Start points to the tutorial

The README now routes new users to a complete first setup walkthrough.

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For a start-to-finish first setup, see the

[new user tutorial](#).

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Tutorial Coverage Screenshot

The added guide covers install, repo wiring, readiness, the Codexa edit loop, success criteria, and troubleshooting.

ADDED GUIDE

New tutorial coverage

The new guide gives first-time users one concrete path through setup and the edit-lifecycle loop.

1. Install

Shows npm and source-checkout install paths plus version verification.

2. Wire a repo

Explains Codex CLI and Claude Code setup without editing source files.

3. Check readiness

Defines session-start freshness, parser errors, dirty files, and doctor.

4. Run the loop

Walks through brief, change-plan, edit, post-edit-review, and test-plan.

5. Verify success

Frames what evidence new users should expect after a Codexa-guided edit.

Troubleshoot

Covers PATH, missing index, missing MCP tools, wrong repo, and heuristic output.

10/10 onboarding blueprint for follow-up work

The PR is now a good docs improvement. To reach a full 10/10 onboarding experience in the product docs, the next slice should make the tutorial executable and self-validating.

Priority	Follow-up	Why it matters
P0	Add a copy-paste sample task with expected command output classes.	Users learn by seeing the first proof loop complete, not by reading command names.
P0	Add a readiness state table: fresh, stale, missing-index, dirty overlay, parser errors, MCP unavailable.	Most first-run failures are setup-state confusion.
P1	Add host-specific tabs or subsections for Codex CLI and Claude Code.	Competing docs reduce confusion by separating environments.
P1	Add a tiny diagram directly in the tutorial: host -> Codexa -> repo index -> proof loop.	Codexa is an unusual support tool; visuals reduce category confusion.
P1	Add expected post-edit-review interpretations: continue, inspect, replan.	The verdicts are core product vocabulary and should be learned before real work.
P2	Add a short FAQ for privacy, generated files, auto-refresh, and semantic retrieval.	These are likely adoption objections for local-first codebase tooling.

Definition of done for a 10/10 tutorial

- A user can complete it in under 10 minutes against any local git repo.
- The tutorial produces one visible artifact of success: a post-edit review and a targeted test plan tied to a tiny change.
- Every setup failure in the first-run path has an immediate recovery command.
- The reader understands what Codexa does not do: it does not replace tests, edit source through MCP, or send core context to a hosted indexer.

SOURCES

Official docs reviewed for competitive analysis

These source URLs were reviewed on 2026-06-16. The analysis paraphrases onboarding structure rather than copying source text.

Source	URL
Claude Code Quickstart	https://code.claude.com/docs/en/quickstart
Cursor Quickstart	https://cursor.com/docs/get-started/quickstart
Aider Installation	https://aider.chat/docs/install.html
Continue Agent Quick Start	https://docs.continue.dev/ide-extensions/agent/quick-start
GitHub Copilot Quickstart	https://docs.github.com/en/copilot/get-started/quickstart
OpenAI Codex CLI	https://developers.openai.com/codex/cli
Model Context Protocol client tutorial	https://modelcontextprotocol.io/docs/develop/build-client
Model Context Protocol introduction	https://modelcontextprotocol.io/docs/getting-started/intro

Validation trail for this PDF

- Screenshots were generated from actual origin/main README content and current PR branch content rendered in a local browser.
- The PDF was rendered back to PNG pages with pdftoppm and visually inspected for clipping, legibility, and page transitions.
- PDF page count and expected extracted text were checked with pypdf.
- Repository gates were run after staging: git diff --check, npm run privacy, and npm run check.